I've Read Thousands of Books. Only 5 Made Me Rich

Channel: Brandon Carter · Published: Oct 11, 2026 · Watch: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=W0HWSyCzi5Y Source: full transcript

📋 Executive Summary

Brandon Carter distills 25 years of reading into 5 actionable books on starting fast, storytelling, persuasion, sales framing, and negotiation — with real student results and business tactics layered throughout.

📑 Contents

- 🚀 Book 1: Ready, Fire, Aim — Start Before You're Ready
- 🎯 The Makeover Madness Strategy — Monetizing the Journey
- 📖 Book 2: Expert Secrets — Storytelling as a Sales Weapon
- 🧠 Book 3: Influence — The Seven Weapons of Persuasion
- 🖼️ Book 4: Pitch Anything — Frame Control in Sales
- 🤝 Book 5: Never Split the Difference — Mirroring, Labeling, and Negotiation

🚀 Book 1: Ready, Fire, Aim — Start Before You're Ready 0:24

- **Book:** *Ready, Fire, Aim* by Michael Masterson (referred to as "Big Mike")
- Core principle: stop waiting for perfect conditions — get out there, start shooting, and adjust your aim as you go
  - Most aspiring entrepreneurs stall indefinitely saying "I'm going to start soon" while waiting for everything to align perfectly
  - "Situations will never be perfect. You'll never be ready. Just get out there and start going."
  - The person trying to get everything perfect almost never succeeds — because they never start
- Brandon's personal approach: "I kind of always had that attitude — I'm just going to jump in, I'll make mistakes and adjust along the way"
  - He describes himself as a "gunslinger" when he entered business
  - As you make adjustments, you're simultaneously making progress
- Practical recommendation: start your business part-time while keeping your day job
  - Most of Brandon's 15,000+ students start this way — full-time job plus side business
  - "Everybody who has a job needs to have some side income money-making opportunity"
  - Reasons: layoffs, firings, or employer business failure can happen with no fault of your own
  - If you have no side income when that happens, you put your family at financial risk
  - If you start making side money *before* you need it, you have a safety net — either bridge income or a full business to transition into

🎯 The Makeover Madness Strategy — Monetizing the Journey 1:38

- A specific tactic Brandon developed inside his program *High Ticket Trainer* that applies the "start before you're ready" principle
- The problem it solves: fitness trainers who want to wait until they're in perfect shape before launching
- **How Makeover Madness works (step by step):**
  - Step 1 — Join the program even if you're out of shape or don't look like a trainer yet
  - Step 2 — Begin a personal fitness protocol and document the journey publicly
  - Step 3 — As visible progress accumulates (even just 5–10 lbs lost in 2–3 weeks), start marketing to people in the shape you *were* in
    - Example pitch: "Hey, here's how I lost 5–10 lbs in 2–3 weeks. DM me if you want more info."
  - Step 4 — Use Brandon's DM scripts to convert followers into paying clients mid-journey
  - Step 5 — Keep documenting and gaining clients as the transformation deepens
  - Step 6 — Once the full transformation is complete, do a public launch
    - Shift from selling privately to selling publicly
    - Example CTA: "Here's how I made this 90-day transformation. Comment 'transformation' below and I'll send you the details."
  - Step 7 — People who are still at the starting point become your hottest leads because they watched the whole journey
- Why it works: people love watching transformations — analogous to *The Biggest Loser* or home renovation shows; you're essentially producing a personal reality show
- **Real student case study — Cory Armstrong:**
  - Cory was out of shape and didn't look like a trainer
  - Brandon told him: "Bro, you got to get in better shape, man. Do the makeover madness protocol."
  - Cory did it and immediately had his highest revenue month ever
  - He now makes approximately **$400,000 per year** as an online trainer
  - Cory in his own words: "Light sales week for me — just $8,300 for the week... so far for the month we're sitting at just over $13K. Last month we finished at $40K... Last year was a record year, man. We finished at **$470,000**."
- **Applying the same principle to other industries (e.g., ad management):**
  - Not an expert yet? Don't position as one — position as someone learning and document that journey
  - Find a business willing to let you run ads for free for one month (they provide the ad spend)
  - Set a public goal, e.g.: "I'm on a mission to make this business an extra $50,000 in the next 30 days"
  - Document daily: what you're doing, what's working, what isn't, even your mistakes
  - If you hit $50K — pitch via the case study
  - If you only hit $10K on $1,000 ad spend — still a 10x ROAS; pitch that instead
  - "Even if you fail, that's the beauty of it" — the journey itself builds credibility and an audience
  - You can start making money mid-journey (e.g., week 2) by adding a CTA like "DM me the word 'ads'"

📖 Book 2: Expert Secrets — Storytelling as a Sales Weapon 7:36

- **Book:** *Expert Secrets* by Russell Brunson
  - Russell Brunson: founder of ClickFunnels, company valued at hundreds of millions of dollars
  - Brandon has won multiple ClickFunnels awards and considers Brunson a personal mentor
- Core lesson focused on: how to tell your story — including your backstory, flaws, messy moments, mistakes, and failures
  - Why it matters: people only buy from people they know, like, and trust
  - The more people know you personally through your story, the more they resonate with you and buy into you
  - Storytelling is also a key differentiator from competitors who have similar products/services
- Brandon's own "Batman-style origin story" that he deploys constantly:
  - His father took his own life right before the 2008 financial collapse
  - He worked four different jobs to support his family
  - Didn't find real success until he started an online fitness business
  - Trained thousands of people, achieved great results
  - Now teaches others to grow their own online fitness businesses
- Why this story is powerful in marketing:
  - Potential clients who've faced hardship think: "If he went through that and I'm going through something, he's the guy who can help me."
  - Or: "If he went through *that*, he can help me get through what I'm going through."
  - That emotional investment is a core copywriting mechanism
- Key insight: "People buy the person more than just the product — a lot of people have products. They've got to pick which *person* they're going to buy it from. The person with the best story is usually going to get the client."
- Actionable takeaway: think about what origin stories and personal narratives you can tell to get people invested not just in your product, but in *you*

> "If you can do that, now you have a cheat code for your business."

- Described as "probably the best book on the subject, especially if you want to build a personal brand that sells"

🧠 Book 3: Influence — The Seven Weapons of Persuasion 9:31

- **Book:** *Influence* by Robert Cialdini
  - Brandon read or listened to this book on audiobook approximately **once a month for a full year**
  - Every reread revealed something new — not because the book changed, but because he had changed: more experience, more knowledge, more dots to connect

- The book covers **seven weapons of influence:**

Weapon	What It Is	How Brandon Applies It
Reciprocity	People feel subconsciously obligated to pay you back after you help them	Give away free advice, free tools, actually help people — they'll often pay back in purchases
Commitment & Consistency	Once someone makes a small public commitment, they find it hard to back out on a subconscious level	Get prospects to state beliefs or small commitments publicly
Social Proof	People trust what others endorse through their actions/reviews	Constantly show testimonials of fitness results AND business results from students
Liking	People are more influenced by people they actually like	Storytelling (per Expert Secrets) makes people like you more
Authority	People subconsciously defer to those in positions of authority	Display credentials and track record: "27 years as a trainer, helped 15,000+ grow online businesses"
Scarcity	Things feel more valuable when fewer are available	Example: Hermès/Richard Mille watches commanding premium prices by limiting annual production
Unity	Bringing people together as a community creates an us-vs-them dynamic	Build community; often seen (and exploited) in politics

- On social proof specifically: "This is why before you buy a product or service — you check the reviews, right? You check the Amazon reviews before you buy the thing."
- On authority: credentials must be real — "They got to be true. You can't be out here lying, making stuff up. You get called out for that. There's no way you could fake something like that for 15 years."
- On content strategy derived from reciprocity: don't just post lifestyle/flex content — create content that genuinely helps people and gives real advice
- Verdict: "Highly suggest you read it if you plan on making money in any capacity."

🖼️ Book 4: Pitch Anything — Frame Control in Sales 12:36

- **Book:** *Pitch Anything* by Oren Klaff
  - Designed for one-to-many sales (not one-on-one)
  - Brandon has read or listened to it **over 100 times**
  - He makes all of his salespeople read this book
  - He actually did an interview with Oren Klaff, who sought *Brandon* out — which Brandon describes as "a dream come true"
- **The core concept: Frame Control**

    - Every conversation is a clash of frames
    - A frame = an ideology wrapped around the conversation
    - Whoever owns the dominant frame controls the interaction
- **Types of frames mentioned:**
    - **Power Frame:** The person commanding the room/stage owns this. When speaking at events, Brandon owns the power frame — he's literally elevated on a platform while everyone else is silent
    - **Prize Frame:** The most powerful frame to own in a sales context
- **How the Prize Frame works in sales:**
    - Normally, the buyer holds power (they have the money) and the seller is chasing
    - The goal is to flip it: make the buyer feel like *they* are selling *you* on why they deserve the program
    - Step-by-step prize frame flip:
        - Start with: "Hey, what made you decide to jump on a call with us?" — they explain their reasons, building investment
        - Follow with: "Why do you think this might be a good fit for you?" — now they're articulating their own desire
        - Escalate: "You've seen all the results we've gotten for other clients — what about that makes you think it could work for you?" — they're selling themselves
        - Peak level: "The thing is, we can't really work with everybody. We only have so many spots on our roster. Why do you think you'll be a good fit for this program?" — they are now fully selling themselves to you, even though they're the one paying
- Brandon also credits learning early frame concepts from mentor Owen of Real Social Dynamics (from the pickup world)
- Verdict: "You definitely want to read this if you're in sales in any capacity."

🤝 Book 5: Never Split the Difference — Mirroring, Labeling, and Negotiation 14:52

- **Book:** *Never Split the Difference* by Chris Voss
    - Chris Voss: former FBI hostage negotiator — negotiated with terrorists and bank robbers
    - "It's nothing compared to the little stuff you and I have to negotiate"
    - Brandon lost his physical copy (it's in storage); uses the Kindle version
- **Tool 1: Mirroring**
    - Definition: repeat the last few words of what someone said to prompt them to elaborate
    - Example: Prospect says "Yeah man, I've been struggling with my weight for the last few years" → you say "Last few years?"
    - They don't just say "yeah" — they open up with full detail: what they tried, why it failed, their whole situation
    - Why it matters in sales: you want the prospect to do **at least 80% of the talking**

    - More information from the prospect = easier to tailor the pitch and close the sale
    - Brandon has done five mirrors in a row and had prospects pour out their entire life story
- **Tool 2: Labeling**
    - Definition: after gathering information through mirrors, summarize what the person said back to them
    - Example label: "So it sounds like you've tried a bunch of things, nothing's worked, you've been going through this for years, and now you finally feel like you've had enough and it's time to make a change."
    - If done correctly, the response is "Yeah, exactly" — they feel deeply understood
    - Effect: builds genuine connection and trust; not manipulation because it requires actually understanding the person
    - Ties back to the core sales principle: people only buy from people they know, like, and trust
- **Critical warning on over-negotiating:**
    - About 10 years ago Brandon felt he had become *too good* at negotiation
    - He was winning negotiations so decisively that they became too one-sided in his favor
    - Result: the other party had no incentive left — they didn't put in their best effort, so Brandon didn't get optimal outcomes even when he "won"
    - Lesson learned: dial back the negotiation so the other party feels they got enough to be genuinely motivated
    - Brandon now sometimes deliberately gives more than he needs to — leaving value on the table — to incentivize the other side to work hard
    - Caveat: "You got to get to that point where you don't need the money like that" to apply this wisdom
- Verdict: "By far the best book on negotiation."